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» MISSING IN ACTION

Central to big wins, these performers are out of the loop

ROHIT SHARMA

The stylish Mumbai right-hander, once called a fitting No.4 after Tendulkar, is now dropped from the team

ROBIN UTHAPPA

One of the most attacking of young batsmen, Uthappa today has lost much ground inside the Indian team

R.P. SINGH

The left-hander, once greatly relied upon by Dhoni, has suffered from injuries and a loss of form at home

odd games of first class cricket. "When they are 19 or 20 they are neither mentally mature nor physically strong enough. If they are dropped, they take a long time to come through a bad phase," Prasad says.

There appears to be another IPL leftover. It is what former selector Sanjay Jagdale calls "attitude". Jagdale says modern India can learn from its greats, "When they lose a match, it hurts. They are always hungry to do well. If they make a mistake, they quickly learn to avoid it. Yes, your talent counts but attitude is the No.1 priority for the team. That is where there is a scope for improvement."

Despite his outward display of a 'positive' attitude, Raina's lack of de-

velopment remains a mystery. Announcing every new arrival as the next superstar is always a bad idea and it is what Raina has grappled with for four seasons. Players involved with the Indian team recently believe that an understanding of his role is key. One says, "You can't have 11 leaders on the field—you will have your leaders and other guys who follow and support." If Raina is to be a 'leader', he needs to be told to change his own mindset about his role.

During the entire Australia series, Dhoni has defended his younger players and their errors. After all, it is they who have given him his best results as a leader and also turned him into a careful accumulator of runs

rather than a batsman who made run chases look like a fireworks display.

What is not known though is what the team management make of and attend to the internal struggles of their rookies. What was made public, or rather leaked, was a 'vision document' given out during the Bangalore training camp before departure to Sri Lanka. Already-gagged coach Gary Kirsten, who passed on its ownership entirely onto his assistant Paddy Upton, didn't turn up during press conferences during the Australia series. An odd move, considering that his team kept floundering.

The BCCI or Kirsten needn't have worried about being nagged over the Upton Papers. That flaky document would not have been the constant query to Kirsten. The most common question would have run like this: Never mind India's historical failing of having "never been an aggressor at war", coach. Why is the India on your watch playing tawdry cricket? ■

The IPL has given an army of young players money and instant fame but they do not have the maturity to switch formats quickly

